

EXISTENTIAL LOSS

Before my college journey, I had a close friend for seven years. His name was Lincoln. We would hang out a lot like seeing movies, going bowling, and working at the same job together. Lincoln was even grateful to have me as a friend and for me changing his life. Our relationship did have a downfall during the summer of 2023 due to my drama, but I was able to take action to correct myself after a hard and honest conversation with Lincoln. When the day came for me to head to the University of Minnesota (UMN), Lincoln and I decided to have breakfast together at my house before I fully left. Lincoln had to leave a bit early after we ate and I gave him a gift, but he told me, “We don’t have to do a special or a proper goodbye. We can still text each other.” Hearing this made my heart warm. I didn’t need to worry about losing Lincoln after all. He was a close friend that I could have forever.

During welcome week and the first week of college classes, I made UMN friends and still talk to my high school friends, especially with Lincoln. Lincoln was even okay helping me with Calculus I. By the second week of college, Lincoln helped me with Calculus I again. Working on Limits, I was frustrated with myself because limits is one of the easiest units in Calculus I. I even told Lincoln that I wished that this was easy. He then replied to my message with “I hate to break it to you, but the first 2 units are the easiest 😞😞.”

Reading Lincoln’s reply made me feel upset on the inside. I then sarcastically said, “Wow... That was constructive. I hate you because you're laughing.”

Lincoln read that message as if I was mad at him and taking it as criticism, when in reality, I wasn’t mad and knew that he wasn’t criticizing me. I was just acting like Anger from *Inside Out*. I then responded, “I know that you weren’t criticizing me. I just feel like you were

laughing or saying that because you think it's easy, making me feel like I am not ready for Calc.”

Later in the day, I checked on him to see how he was feeling after that little drama we had earlier. I got no response. I tried again the next day, still nothing. I messaged him throughout the whole week and yet nothing from him. This was confusing me. “Why isn’t he responding?”, I asked to myself. The next week, I decided to message him on Snapchat since he wasn’t getting back to me through iMessage. Looking through Snapchat, I couldn’t find him. The same went with TikTok, I also couldn’t find him. Then I attempted on Discord. I was able to write a message, but I got this message from the Discord bot saying, “Your message could not be delivered. This is usually because... the recipient is only accepting direct messages from friends.”

I was even more perplexed. I asked myself more questions, “What is going on? Why can’t I find his Snap and TikTok and message him on Discord?”

Throughout September and October, I would occasionally message him via iMessage as it’s the only source that I can still send messages to him and hopefully get a word back from him, but I received zero messages from him. I started to get annoyed at this. One day, I went to see one of my high school friends that lived in the same dorm as me to see if he could find Lincoln on Snapchat. He was able to find him and when I showed him that I wasn’t able to find Lincoln, he was puzzled and didn’t know why this was the case. Later that same day, I ate dinner with Jack – another high school friend of mine – and told him about Lincoln not talking to me back since September 11th. He answered to my statement with, “Maybe he’s busy at his end.”

I replied with a counter argument, “Well if that’s the case, then why couldn’t he tell me? Is it that hard to simply say ‘I am busy and I need a break from this relationship for now?’”

“I don’t know... I would say give him some time and limit the messaging, okay.”

Following Jack's suggestion, I messaged Lincoln two TikTok videos two weeks apart in November. Yet, still nothing... On Thanksgiving day, I talked to Lincoln's brother to catch up on things and about Lincoln not talking to me. He told me, "I don't have Lincoln on Snap and I think he deleted his account and the app, but he'll be happy to see you during Winter Break." Reading this message built optimism inside me. Hoping to see Lincoln and get an answer of why he hasn't been talking to me.

On December 1st, Jack asked if I wanted to eat with him in his dining hall and I accepted his offer. While eating with him, I told him the information that I got from Lincoln's brother about Lincoln deleting his Snapchat account and the app which explains why I wasn't able to find him on Snapchat. Jack, however, pulled Snapchat on his phone and showed me that Lincoln still has his account up. This made me cross. "Okay. This is getting ridiculous! I need to know what the hell is going on. He hasn't been replying to any of my messages since September 11, I can't message him on Discord, and I can't find his Snap and TikTok!" Then, a lightbulb popped inside my head. I created a plan with Jack to finally get to the bottom of what is going on with Lincoln. Jack agrees to do it. Jack first talked to Lincoln as a normal conversation. He then gave me a nod, indicating that he's going to mention me to Lincoln. I was thrilled to finally get the truth. I was about to take another bite of my crispy grilled cheese sandwich until Jack finally received the truth and said, "He... He says that he wants you to forget about him."

Hearing that line, I immediately stopped eating. I was extremely puzzled. "What?!"

"Yeah. That's what he said. He wants you to forget about him."

"Wait. Wait. Wait... What about him blocking me on everything?"

"Yes. He also blocked you on everything."

Gaining the truth from Jack about Lincoln, more confusion came into my mind, my heart shattered into pieces, tears started to come out my eyes, my body shocked severely, I couldn't eat anymore, and I breathed heavily. Jack and I went to a private room so no one could see me cry in the dining hall. In the room, I asked out loud in pain, "Why would he do this to me after everything we've been through? This isn't like him at all." After a conversation with Jack about the situation, walking back to my dorm still in tears in the cold winter night, I couldn't stop thinking about Lincoln's betrayal act and words. I even wished that September 11, 2023 told me that something unexpectedly terrible was going to happen.

The next day, I called up Jack to tell him I was feeling a bit better and wanting to get the true message that Lincoln texted him. He agreed and said, "Oh, I feel bad that I blocked him on everything. He wouldn't stop texting and calling since we left... He gotta move on. It's probably better if he finds other people. Otherwise, he will only talk to me." Copying the line onto a notebook, I asked Jack to clarify what Lincoln said. He told me that Lincoln wants me to let go of him, which I find very baffling considering what he said to me before I left. Throughout the rest of the Fall 2023 Semester and Winter Break, I told a lot of people about the situation and they all felt bad for me while some were surprised to hear that Lincoln would do such a childish, uncalled for act on me. Even my family understands how painful this was for me. My high school IEP teacher, however, suggested that it's probably worth fighting to get Lincoln back since he knows our positive history and the best way to do it was writing a simple letter to him. While I got positive empathy from everything and a good suggestion, all of this still didn't help me fully feel better emotionally. My mind lingered onto the negative betrayal Lincoln acted on. It even came to a point where I was going through an existential crisis, seeing life in a negative

light and overly worried about my high school friends cutting me off and then my UMN friends doing it to me once I'm done with college. I needed help. I needed therapy.

By the time the Spring 2024 Semester came in, I started to have my therapy sessions. In the first session, I spoke out to my therapist about my situation with Lincoln, why it hurt me a lot, and my goal of being okay with letting go of Lincoln. My therapist likes my goal and recommended some activities to do like writing positive things about Lincoln. Within the one month of having that goal and continuing seeing my therapist bi-weekly, the progress didn't go very well. Because my goal involved me letting go of Lincoln, my mind keeps rejecting it due to my heart wanting Lincoln back in my life. So I created a new goal. The new goal was to let go of Lincoln's actions (i.e. what he did to me) so then it can help me be okay with fully letting him go. My therapist likes the new goals and we decided to push forwards with it. Throughout the rest of the semester, I made excellent progress with old and new activities to support me. I kept writing positive lines about Lincoln, talking to people that pleased me, watching Bluey, and reenacting stuff that me and Lincoln did after a high school day.

The day finally came, April 29, my last therapy session. I reported to my therapist with blessing news that I am fully okay with letting go of Lincoln. My therapist expressed his proudness for my growth and accomplishment in reaching my goals. However, I still planned to send Lincoln a letter like what my high school IEP teacher suggested. When the semester ended and I arrived back home, I began writing down my letter to Lincoln, telling him about what has happened to me, I have a gift for him, and I hope that he can reply back to me soon. Three days later, I was finally ready to do it. It was raining outside. My brother drove me to his house and parked far away so his family won't see us. I ran to his house unnoticed. Sneaking to his letterbox on the door, I opened it slowly and was about to put the letter through, but then I

stopped. I thought about all the amazing connections I had at UMN and Lincoln being okay without me. I put the letter in my pocket and closed the letterbox. I walked away quietly. My brother witnessed everything. Entering in the car, my brother asked me, “Why didn't you put the letter through?”

I answered confidently, “Because... I'll be okay without him... I'm letting him go.” The rain suddenly stopped. The clouds blew away. The sun shined bright. Driving away from Lincoln's house, I saw Lincoln in the living room watching TV with a different friend. I popped my head out of the window to sniff the air. I then told myself, “Losing Lincoln sucks and not easy to accept, but I am happy with the connections that I have in my life now. I know that we'll be okay without each other anymore. Thanks for the memories Lincoln.”

PROCESS STATEMENT

Craft elements that I heavily incorporated in my piece are participle phrases. The reason is because I like using this writing skill alot and it's an easy one for me to use. Another element I included is using pseudonyms, primarily on Lincoln, because if I ever decide to publish this story to the public, I don't think it's fair to have the actual person's name (my close friend that blocked me) on the story and receive backlash from the world for what he did to me.

During my writing process, I already know what I want to include in this nonfiction piece. My starting point was basically knowing which story I want to write about and I already know what I want to write about even before this class started. My favorite part about writing this essay is me telling a story that actually happened to me and sharing lessons that people can take away from my nonfiction writing. This story in particular I want to share out how losing a

close friend by them blocking you can feel it. One more thing I like about this story is the title because this is about me going through an existential crisis of losing a close friend, hence why it's called *Existential Loss*.

Funnily enough, I had plans for making this story back in May 2024. But there was an animated film that I saw in June 2024 called *Robot Dreams*, which does have the same message/theme that I have, but the stories are different. I also didn't know that *Robot Dreams* was a graphic novel. Watching the film and reading the novel made me motivated to wanting to write about my experience on losing a close friend and how it affected me while giving out the message that relationships do change (good or bad), it's okay to let go of someone that you were close with for a long time, and if the bits with your close friend were mostly happy, then maybe that makes it all worth it (this message comes from an episode of Bluey, *Camping*).

If I were to write this story with the rubric included, I would like to not follow the word count. If I am wanting to actually tell the full true story, then I would need to be longer than 2000 words. By avoiding the maximum word count, I could include the part that Lincoln came back into my life for a bit, me pondering about fully continuing the friendship or not, Lincoln telling me that losing him should of been like ripping off a band aid, and him blocking me everything again, giving me another round of "Existential Loss". With this part in the story, the reader can also learn that losing a close person is not an easy life task and won't be a quick process. So for this, I decided to write this true story essay as if I was going to make a movie out of this experience.